

Stress Triggers Identification Worksheet

FREE RESOURCE · EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE

Stress Triggers Identification Worksheet

A structured worksheet for identifying personal and professional stress triggers — reflection prompts and coping strategy planning.

Trigger Framework

Personal vs Professional

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HOW TO USE THIS WORKSHEET

Work through this in a calm moment, not in the middle of a stressful week — it's much easier to identify patterns with some distance from them. Be as specific as you can throughout; “everything is stressful” is not a trigger, but “unplanned client calls after 5pm” is.

Trigger Identification Framework

A stress trigger is a specific situation, person, interaction, or condition that reliably provokes a stress response — not vague background stress, but an identifiable, repeating pattern. Consider these common categories as a starting point.

Workload / deadlines

Specific people or relationships

Uncertainty / ambiguity

Public performance / scrutiny

Conflict

Lack of control

Financial pressure

Health concerns

Time scarcity

Feeling micromanaged

What situations make your stomach drop or chest tighten before anything has even happened?

Anticipatory stress often points to your clearest triggers — the reaction arrives before the event does.

What types of interactions do you find yourself dreading in advance?

Name specific people, meeting types, or conversations, not just "difficult people" in the abstract.

What recurring situations leave you feeling drained or on edge afterward, even if nothing went visibly wrong?

A trigger doesn't have to involve an obvious crisis to be real and worth naming.

Personal Triggers

Life Outside Work

What personal situations reliably trigger stress for you?

Consider family dynamics, financial pressure, health concerns, relationship conflict, or time scarcity.

Which of these personal triggers tend to spill over into your work?

Professional Triggers

At Work

What workplace situations reliably trigger stress for you?

Consider deadlines, specific stakeholders, public speaking, ambiguous expectations, or performance reviews.

Which of these professional triggers tend to follow you home?

Early Warning Signs

Stress rarely arrives without warning — it usually announces itself first through physical, emotional, or behavioural signals, often before you consciously register feeling stressed at all.

Physical <i>e.g. tension headache, clenched jaw, shallow breathing, stomach issues, fatigue</i> _____ _____	Emotional <i>e.g. irritability, feeling overwhelmed, anxiety, low motivation, cynicism</i> _____ _____	Behavioural <i>e.g. procrastination, snapping at people, withdrawing, overworking, skipping meals</i> _____ _____
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What is the very first sign — in any category — that tells you stress is building, before it becomes overwhelming?
This is usually the most useful signal to watch for, since it gives you the most time to respond.

Coping Strategy Planning

For each major trigger you identified above, plan a response in advance — while you're calm, not in the moment the trigger actually appears.

Trigger	Early Warning Sign	In-the-Moment Strategy	Longer-Term Strategy

REVISIT THIS PERIODICALLY

Triggers shift as your role, relationships, and circumstances change. Revisit this worksheet every few months, particularly after a significant change at work or at home, rather than treating it as a one-time exercise.